

ised by them. This trend is a fact of life in South Korea: computer gaming has already become a mass sport—millions of viewers watch the World Cyber Games on dedicated gaming TV channels while others get their fix from live streams on Web sites.

The World Cyber Games (WCG) is, in fact, the Olympics of video games. Started in 2001, WCG has seen rapid growth, both in terms of scope and visibility. Each country sends its own team to the games where they slug it out with gamers from over 70 countries for medals and glory. During the seventh edition of the games in Seattle last year, 700 gamers, selected from 74 countries from a pool of over 1.25 million gamers competed for \$2.7 million in cash and prizes. This year's championship—to be held in November in Cologne, Germany—promises to be even bigger and better than before. The top three countries last year were the US, Brazil and Korea—in that order.

Apart from pitting elite gamers against each other, such events are also great places for companies to launch gaming hardware or demo yet to be released games. That way the companies are able to get customer feedback from the gamers and also the regular users who throng the venue.

The Players

Johnathan "Fatal1ty" Wendel is to gaming what Tiger Woods is to golf, or Lance Armstrong was to cycling. A 26-year-old, he is the most recognisable and has been the best for a long time in games like *Quake*, *Counter*

Strike, *Call of Duty* and *Painkiller*. He has been featured in plenty of TV shows and magazines. Like any other serious athlete, he practices upwards of 5 hours everyday which might stretch to 10 hours before any important championship. He endorses and also helps companies design hardware like keyboard, mice, headsets, motherboards and cabinets that are customised for gamers. His company also conducts two-week courses in gaming at universities like Stanford and UCLA where for \$3,499 a gamer will get tutoring from Wendel himself in *Unreal Tournament 3*. These courses never run empty.

In South Korea, the pro gaming phenomenon has gone to an extremely different level with top players becoming major celebrities. They endorse products from footwear to cereals and have their photos splashed in newspapers and TV. To get a perspective of how popular gaming is, an estimated 17 million of 48 million Koreans regularly play games.

So encouraging the situation there is for professional gaming that many gamers from other countries have settled there permanently to make a career in gaming. PC and online gaming is the rage in South Korea with the most popular games being *Starcraft* and *Warhammer*, in which they are virtually unbeatable.

The Indian Scene

As with most things related to computers and the Internet, gaming has not yet caught on in a

Interview With Gamers

Dhruv Mody

Dhruv 'NOSTalgic' Mody was a professional gamer who had represented India in the 2005 World Cyber Games held at Singapore. His forte is car racing and he had reached up to the final 16 in the *NFS* segment during the event.

To pursue pro gaming, he dropped out of college. "You need to devote at least four-five hours everyday to gaming if you are planning on playing at a serious level. I was lucky because my parents fully supported my activities."

After coming back from WCG, Mody became an employee at Games2Win where he was game master for *CTRacer*, their car racing MMOG. Why did he stop playing professionally? "There were various factors. Money was one of them. Also the realisation that right now in India, games are not enough to sustain yourself." Mody, 23, has resigned from Games2Win and is now planning on finishing his graduation.

About his experiences at WCG, Mody is of the opinion that Indian gamers are not up to world standards as they don't have much quality competition. He says that WCG was a great learning experience for him and he is confident that such exposures would go a long way in improving the level of gaming in India.

Yash "Bugg" Mayekar

When we called up Yash he was busy practising for the upcoming

Mumbai WCG trials that would be held in the next month. The guy was pepped up and confident of his chances in both the Mumbai and India trials, but was not very sure about Cologne, where the world finals would be held. This is the second time Yash has represented India in the World Cyber Games; last year he was in Seattle as part of the Indian team.

His typical day involves gaming, and some more gaming. Because it is the season, he plays a minimum of six hours everyday with players from around the world. Competing in *Project Gotham Racing* on Xbox 360, Yash also plays FPS games like *Crysis*, where he has won plenty of prizes in gaming events. He won a cool Rs 4 lakh in the Vixture game tournament held in Mumbai last month, while he earns almost Rs 3,000 to Rs 4,000 per week by winning various gaming tournaments organised across Mumbai and neighbouring areas. Not bad for a 20-year-old who gave up college to concentrate on gaming full time.

What's the biggest challenge to gaming in India? "Gamers face opposition from parents. That's one big dampener. I am glad my parents support me." Any other problems? "There is no consistency in the way rules are applied and this lessens the credibility of gaming meets. The organisers need to be savvy and more professional. For example in one event we had to game standing and I had to troubleshoot my rig. Things have to improve."